translate the Bible into Tamil but came to realise that the combination of British rule and Christian missionary activity was undermining both Dravidian culture and his own high-caste Shaivism. In 1850 he set up his own vernacular Tamil printing press to counter what he saw as the anti-Hindu propaganda of the missionaries, as well as establishing Tamil-medium schools in imitation of the mission schools. But Navalar's reforming zeal was marred by his prejudices. His aggressive promotion of high-caste Shaivism and his support for the privileges enjoyed by those same castes made him as many enemies as friends. Even so, that same zeal inspired many young Tamils with such giveaway South Indian high-caste names as Aiyer, Iyengar, Mudaliar and Pillai to take up Tamil cultural studies, many of them as graduates of Jesuit colleges and Madras University.

One such scholar was Mu Raghava Iyengar, born a year before Navalar's death in 1879. As a leading member of what was named the 4th Madurai Tamil Sangam, set up in 1901 in imitation of the legendary Sangams of the distant past, Iyengar specialised in the study of early Tamil literary sources, inscriptions and place names, in the course of which he discovered that the tradition of a southern migration and ancestral origins in a pitcher was also to be found among other Tamil-language-based communities, most notably the Kannada-speaking Chalukyas, who had ruled over much of the western Deccan between the tenth and twelfth centuries, and the Hoysalas, who had followed them in what is now Karnataka. Both these groups claimed descent from a cattle-herding people called Yadavas with their ancestral home in Dwaraka, from which they had been dispersed after the death of Lord Krishna. Here was further confirmation of a migration south, with or without the sage Agastya.